

Θεόφραστος ὁ Ἐρέσιος

Theophrastus of Eresus on Plants, Stones, and Character

eul_aid: ljk

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)
Dialect: Φιλοσοφική Ἀττική [Attic Philosophical](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Peripatetic](#)

Theophrastus was a Greek philosopher who lived from approximately 371 to 287 BCE. He was born in Eresus on the island of Lesbos and moved to Athens for his education. There, he first studied under Plato and later became the principal student and close associate of Aristotle.

Upon Aristotle's death, Theophrastus was named his successor and became the second head of the Peripatetic school at the Lyceum, a position he held for about 35 years. Under his leadership, the school flourished and grew significantly. Like his teacher, he faced political difficulties in Athens related to Macedonian influence and spent a short time in exile before returning.

He was an extraordinarily prolific writer. Ancient sources credit him with over 200 treatises covering nearly every branch of philosophy and science, including logic, metaphysics, ethics, and physics, though most are now lost. His most famous surviving works are on botany: **Inquiry into Plants** and **Explanations of Plants**. These texts represent the most systematic and influential botanical studies from the ancient world. Other important surviving works include the **Characters**, a series of short sketches of flawed personality types, and fragments on metaphysics, logic, and sensory perception.

Theophrastus's historical importance is twofold. First, as Aristotle's immediate successor, he was crucial for preserving, developing, and in some cases questioning Aristotelian philosophy, thereby ensuring the survival and influence of the Peripatetic school. Second, through his specialized scientific works, particularly in botany, he made lasting empirical contributions. His botanical texts remained authoritative for centuries, and his **Characters** influenced later comic and ethical writing. His doxographical works also played a key role in preserving the ideas of earlier philosophers for later generations.

Works (20)

- [Χαρακτήρες](#) · [Characters](#) · 153 passages
- [Περὶ φυτῶν ἱστορία](#) · [Enquiry into Plants](#) · 743 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα διάφορα](#) · [Fragments 13-190](#) · 240 passages
- [Ἐκ τῶν μετὰ τὰ φυσικά](#) · [From the Metaphysics](#) · 16 passages
- [Περὶ φυτῶν αἰτιῶν](#) · [On Causes of Plants](#) · 140 passages
- [Περὶ τῆς ἰλιγγιάδος](#) · [On Dizziness](#) · 13 passages
- [Περὶ τῆς ἐκλογῆς ἀρχόντων](#) · [On Electing Magistrates](#) · 8 passages
- [Περὶ Δειλίας](#) · [On Faintheartedness](#) · 7 passages

- [Περὶ πυρός · On Fire](#) · 74 passages
- [Περὶ Παραλύσεως · On Paralysis](#) · 1 passages
- [Περὶ εὐσεβείας · On Piety](#) · 23 passages
- [Περὶ αἰσθήσεως καὶ τῶν αἰσθητῶν · On Sense and Sensibles](#) · 90 passages
- [Περὶ τῶν Σημείων τῶν Ὑδάτων, Ἀνέμων, Θυελλῶν, καὶ Εὐδίας · On Signs of Waters, Winds, Storms, and Fair Weather](#) · 114 passages
- [Περὶ Ὁσμῶν · On Smells](#) · 144 passages
- [Περὶ λίθων · On Stones](#) · 72 passages
- [Περὶ Ἰδρώτων · On Sweats](#) · 40 passages
- [Περὶ τῶν αἰτιῶν τῶν φυτῶν · On the Causes of Plants](#) · 595 passages
- [Περὶ Πόνων · On Toils](#) · 36 passages
- [Περὶ Ἀνέμων · On Winds](#) · 124 passages
- [Γνώμαι περὶ φυσικῶν · Opinions-Physics](#) · 28 passages

Other Peripatetic Authors

- [Ἀγαθαρχίδης ὁ Κνίδιος · Agatharchides of Cnidus](#) · 4 works
- [Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἀφροδισιεύς · Alexander of Aphrodisias II](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀνδρόνικος ὁ Ῥόδιος · Andronicus of Rhodes](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀρίστων ὁ Κεῖος · Aristo of Ceos](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀριστόβουλος ὁ Ἰουδαῖος · Aristobulus the Jewish Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀριστοκλῆς ὁ Μεσσηνίος · Aristocles of Messene](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀριστόμβροτος ὁ φιλόσοφος · Aristombrotus the Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀρίστων ὁ Κεῖος · Ariston of Ceos](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀσπάσιος ὁ Περιπατητικός · Aspasius the Peripatetic](#) · 1 work
- [Βοηθὸς ὁ Σιδώνιος · Boethus of Sidon](#) · 1 work
- [Χαμαιλέων ὁ Ἡρακλεώτης · Chamaeleon of Heraclea Pontica](#) · 2 works
- [Κλέαρχος ὁ Σολεύς · Clearchus of Soli](#) · 1 work